PIA3123 Theories of Development — Week 4: Human Development and Sustainable Development

1. Framing: Is Development More Than GDP? (slide 3)

Keywords: economic growth, national aggregates, well-being, freedoms, critique of the mainstream

- Have we been too focused on mainstream approaches centred on **economic growth and national aggregates**?
- Are we defining development too **narrowly** — reducing it to income and production instead of **people's well-being and freedoms**?
- The week's two alternatives answer that dissatisfaction from different directions:
    - Human Development shifts the unit of concern from the national economy to the **individual and what they can do**.
    - Sustainable Development shifts the time horizon from the present to **future generations**.

→ Arc of the week: from *how much is produced* (GDP) → to *what people can be and do* (capabilities) → to *whether it can last* (sustainability).

2. The Basic Needs Approach (slides 4–5)

Keywords: ILO, World Bank, minimum standard of living, redistribution, state obligation, intangibles

2.1 Origins: ILO, then World Bank (slide 4)

Keywords: 1976, employment, one world problem, poorest groups, institutional uptake

- Ideas picked up first by the International Labour Organisation and later by the World Bank.
- ILO (1976), *Employment, Growth and Basic Needs: A One World Problem*, set out the parameters of the early approach: basic needs are 'the minimum standard of living which a society should set for the poorest groups of its people'.
- Two built-in moves (memorise): the benchmark is **societal**, not universal ("a society should set" it); the target is **relative** — "the poorest groups", not an abstract average citizen.

2.2 What Basic Needs Theory Demanded (slide 5)

Keywords: necessities, public goods, political participation, agency achievements, growth vs redistribution

- Required **basic necessities, public goods and political participation**, and placed obligations on states — **not entirely appreciated among Third World governments**.
- Needs are both **physical** (e.g. minimum calorie consumption) and **intangible** — what Sen was to call 'agency achievements' — of participation, empowerment and community life.
- Verdict: growth-based models of development are flawed; redistributive models must include both income and intangibles.

→ Basic Needs already seeds the capabilities critique: what matters is not merely what is delivered, but what people are enabled to **do**.

3. From Famines to Entitlements (slides 6–7)

Keywords: famine, natural disaster vs human action, entitlement, command over commodities, rights and opportunities

3.1 The Famine Puzzle (slide 6)

Keywords: causation, food availability, distribution, entry point to Sen

- Provocation: **What causes famines — natural disasters, or human actions?**
- Entry point to Sen: famines can occur **without any large fall in total food availability**, because what kills is the failure of people's **entitlements** — their ability to command food through the rights and opportunities they hold.
- *Example:* a drought that barely dents national food output still produces famine if the poor lose the work or wages that let them buy food, while others eat normally.

→ Development is about **command over resources and opportunities**, not aggregate supply.

3.2 Entitlements and the Capabilities Approach (slide 7)

Keywords: Sen, Nussbaum, beyond basic needs, commodity bundles, rights

- Amartya Sen (b. 1933, Indian economist) and Martha Nussbaum (b. 1947, US philosopher) built on — but **moved beyond** — basic human needs, toward the required **entitlements** for developing capabilities.
- Sen defines entitlements as 'the set of alternative commodity bundles that a person can command in a society using the totality of rights and opportunities that he or she faces'.
- Key move (memorise): from *what people need* to *what they can actually command*, given their rights and opportunities — entitlements are **socially and legally mediated**.

4. Capabilities: Beings and Doings (slide 8)

Keywords: capability deprivation, beings and doings, substantive freedoms, the life they value, beyond commodities

- **Human poverty exists when there is a deprivation of capability** — poverty is not merely low income.
- A person's capability to live a good life is the set of valuable **'beings and doings'** accessible to them:
    - *Beings:* good health, adequate nourishment, literacy.
    - *Doings:* employment or other economic activity, participation, care, movement.
- Capabilities are substantive freedoms that allow people to be who they want to be and do what they want to do.
- Emphasis falls on the individual's **ability to achieve the kind of life they value**, as opposed to the **acquisition of commodities**.
- *Example:* two people with equal incomes but unequal health, schooling, gender norms or political rights have unequal capabilities — income equality is not capability equality.

→ Same income, different freedom: why commodity- and income-based measures are insufficient by construction.

5. Development as Freedom (slide 9)

Keywords: real freedoms, means and ends, five instrumental freedoms, not a byproduct

- In *Development as Freedom*, Sen redefines development as the process of expanding the real freedoms the people enjoy.
- Crucial formulation: **freedom is both the means and the ends of development** — not a byproduct. *As end,* expanding freedom is what development is for; *as means,* people with freedoms (to participate, trade, claim, organise) drive further development.
- Sen classifies freedoms into five (memorise): **political freedoms** (voice, elections, association); **economic facilities** (markets, credit, employment); **social opportunities** (education, health); **transparency guarantees** (openness, trust); **protective security** (safety nets).
- *Example:* famines are prevented less by food stockpiles than by democratic accountability and a free press — political freedom as a means to protective security.

→ One-liner: **capabilities tell us what a person can do; freedom makes the route and the destination the same thing.**

6. Evolution: Gender Justice and the Human Development Approach (slide 10)

Keywords: gender relations, gender justice, quality of life, gender-specific measures, UNDP, HDR

- **Gender enters the theory** through Nussbaum, who sought to define the capabilities **"required"** for a high quality of life.

    - Gender was revealed as a **key determinant of the quality of life** → analysis of gender relations and **gender-specific development measures**.

- **Institutional outcome:** Basic Needs + Capabilities + Sen's freedoms laid the foundation for the Human Development Approach → the UNDP **Human Development Report** and Index.
- Nussbaum (2003) is the supplementary reading on this extension (capabilities as fundamental entitlements).

→ Trajectory of the lecture's first half: **needs → entitlements → capabilities → freedoms → institution and index.**

7. Measuring Human Development: The HDI (slide 11)

Keywords: three dimensions, indicators, life expectancy, schooling, GNI per capita, composite index

The Human Development Index (HDI) combines three dimensions (slide 11):

- **Long and healthy life** — life expectancy at birth → life expectancy index.
- **Knowledge** — expected years of schooling + mean years of schooling → education index.
- **A decent standard of living** — GNI per capita (PPP $) → GNI index.
- Note the deliberate choices: **GNI not GDP**, and **years of schooling, not enrolment** — income is a means, and knowledge is measured as achieved.
- *Example:* two countries with equal income can rank differently on HDI because of life expectancy or schooling — the intended corrective to GDP-only ranking.

→ The HDI is the theory's operational test: are the **people**, not the economy, improving?

8. The Millennium Development Goals, 2000–2015 (slides 12–13)

Keywords: MDGs, UNDP, World Bank, heterodox economists, targets, baseline, achieved vs missed

8.1 What the MDGs Were (slide 12)

Keywords: UNDP meets World Bank, heterodox influence, 2000–2015, global targets

- Characterised as **"UNDP meets World Bank"** — the human development agenda merged with the Bank's poverty agenda.
- **Heterodox economists' influence is visible** in the social and human framing.
- Timeframe **2000–2015**, with quantified, time-bound targets.

8.2 Scorecard: Achieved vs Missed (slide 13)

Keywords: halving poverty, hunger, education, gender parity, mortality, malaria, water, environment

Our World in Data summary of MDG targets — baseline vs target vs achieved final level (slide 13):

- **Achieved:** extreme poverty halved (47% → 14%, target 23.5%); gender parity in education (indices 0.98/0.98/1.01); malaria reversed (158 → 94 per 1,000 at risk); drinking water, 24% → 9% without access (target 12%).
- **Missed:** decent work (62% → 60%, target 100%); hunger (23.3% → 12.9%, target 11.5%, close); primary education (83% → 91%); under-five mortality (90 → 43 per 1,000, target 30); maternal mortality (380 → 210 per 100,000, target 95); reproductive health access (antenatal care 35% → 52%, contraceptives 55% → 64%); HIV/AIDS (3.5M → 2.1M new cases per year, target 0; treatment 3% → 45%); TB (172 → 142 per 100,000, target under 172); sanitation (46% → 32% without access, target 23%); the environmental cluster — sustainable development principles "nearly all deteriorating" and continued biodiversity loss (Red List Index).
- MDG8 (Global Partnership) is excluded — **no easily quantifiable targets** (slide 13 footnote).

→ Pattern (memorise): **poverty, gender parity, malaria and water were met; employment, education quality, health and the entire environmental cluster were missed.** The environment is where the framework failed most visibly — the bridge to Part 2.

9. Critiques of Human Development (slides 14–16)

Keywords: fetishism of numbers, data quality, representation, neoliberalism with a human face

9.1 Fetishism of Numbers (slide 14)

Keywords: technocratic measurement, deeper transformation, indicators vs capabilities, ASER, learning outcomes

- The HDI risks reducing people-centred development to a technocratic measurement exercise, losing sight of deeper transformation.
- Sharp question: **do improvements in development indicators necessarily reflect real expansion of human capabilities?**
- *Example:* ASER 2018 (Annual Status of Education Report, India) — around **50% of Class 5 students could not read a Class 2-level text; only 23.8% could do simple division**. Enrolment and infrastructure improved; real learning did not.

→ Enrolment is an input indicator; **learning is the capability**. Where the two diverge, the index flatters reality.

9.2 Poor Data Quality and Representation (slide 15)

Keywords: representative data, regional disparity, outdated data, rosy picture, planetary pressure, Hickel

- India's HDI data is **not representative in certain dimensions** — regional disparities, outdated or coarse data — so the HDI may give a rosier picture than the lived reality in some regions: an aggregate hides the distribution it is meant to capture.
- See also Hickel (2023), *The limits of the UN's Planetary pressure-adjusted HDI* — an environmental correction to the index, bridging to the sustainability half of the lecture.

9.3 Adjunct to Neoliberalism (slide 16)

Keywords: structural adjustment, human face, safety nets, softening not replacing, Pieterse

- Charge: human development acted as an **adjunct to neoliberalism** — giving structural adjustment or neoliberal reforms a "human face" (basic needs, safety nets) often meant **softening market liberalisation rather than replacing it**.
- Jan Nederveen Pieterse: human development risks being reduced to business-as-usual with a human face.

→ Critical template reused against sustainable development: **humane outcomes delivered inside an unreformed growth model.**

10. Sustainable Development: Definition and Institutional History (slides 19–20, 22–24)

Keywords: Brundtland, intergenerational equity, needs, decision-making framework, Rio+20, three dimensions

10.1 The Brundtland Definition (slide 19)

Keywords: no single definition, future generations, needs of the present, 1987

- Framing fact: Sustainable Development **lacks a single definition** — the central concept is contested from the outset.
- The canonical one (memorise): 'Development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs' (Brundtland Commission 1987, 41). Gro Harlem Brundtland chaired it.
- Built on **needs** — the concept from the Basic Needs approach — plus a new **intergenerational** dimension.

10.2 Needs, Equity and Culture (slide 20)

Keywords: productive potential, equitable opportunities, evolving concept of needs, cultural variation

- 'Societies need to meet human needs both by increasing productive potential and by ensuring equitable opportunities for all' (Brundtland Commission 1987, 44).
- Two clauses, two theories in miniature: **productive potential** = growth model; **equitable opportunities** = capabilities model.
- Slide questions: how does 'development' contribute to the **evolving concept of needs**? And 'needs' are defined differently in different cultures — no culture-free list exists.

10.3 As a Decision-Making Framework (slide 22)

Keywords: correct not replace, environmentally protective, alternative to binaries

- Sustainable development works as a **decision-making framework**: it would **correct but not replace** the existing international development model, ensure development is **environmentally protective or restorative**, and displace the binary **"environment or development"** narratives that have dominated public and private political discourse.

→ The week's second "human face" move: not overturning the growth model but constraining and greening it.

10.4 Rio+20 and "The Future We Want" (slides 23–24)

Keywords: UNCSD, 2012, Rio de Janeiro, Earth Summit, outcome document, growth first

- Rio+20 — the United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development — was the **third** international conference on sustainable development, held in **Rio de Janeiro in 2012**, following the 1992 Earth Summit and the 2002 World Summit.
- *The Future We Want* reaffirms achieving sustainable development by promoting sustained, inclusive and equitable economic growth, creating greater opportunities for all, reducing inequalities, raising basic standards of living... and promoting integrated and sustainable management of natural resources and ecosystems (UN General Assembly 2012, para. 4).
- Hegemony check: **growth is reaffirmed first** — the environment appears as *supporting* development.

10.5 What Is To Be Sustained? (slide 21)

Keywords: natural resources, income from resources, production, consumption, unspecified object

- Unresolved question: what exactly is to be sustained — the slide offers four conflicting candidates: natural resources? income generated from natural resources? production? consumption? Sustaining current **consumption** is precisely what is unsustainable for **resources**.

→ Hold this question — it returns in the critiques (slides 30–31) and the conclusion (slide 34).

11. The Sustainable Development Goals (slides 25–26)

Keywords: 17 goals, targets, three dimensions, balance, universal, action-oriented, government-led

- The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) succeeded the MDGs from 2015, with **17 goals and their targets** (slides 25 and 28 show the full set).
- General Assembly mandate (UN General Assembly 2012, paras. 246–7):

    - Goals must "address and incorporate in a **balanced way all three dimensions** of sustainable development and their inter-linkages" — economic, social, environmental.
    - They must be action-oriented, concise and easy to communicate, limited in number, aspirational, global in nature and universally applicable to all countries — while "taking into account different national realities, capacities and levels of development and respecting national policies and priorities".
    - Implementation is **government-led**: "Governments should drive implementation with the active involvement of all relevant stakeholders".

- **Discussion task (slide 29):** how closely do the SDGs align with Sen's *Development as Freedom*, and to what extent do they exhibit **coherence** in objectives and actions?

    - Alignment test: Goal 4 → social opportunities; Goal 16 → political freedoms and transparency; Goal 1 → protective security; Goal 10 → inequality.
    - Coherence test: does Goal 8's growth imperative undercut Goals 13, 12 and 10?

12. Critiques of Sustainable Development (slides 30–31)

Keywords: weak sustainability, growth vs sustainability, inequality, technocentric, ethnocentric, commodification

12.1 The SDGs: Weak Sustainability and Incoherence (slide 30)

Keywords: weak sustainability, irreconcilable growth, inequality ignored, Salleh, WTO

- Three objections to the SDGs: they **enforce a weak sustainability** (compensating for nature rather than protecting it); they **fail to reconcile growth and sustainability**; they **ignore inequality**.
- Ariel Salleh (feminist scholar): the SDG proposals "are not just unrealistic but **undemocratic**, since the goals are to be realised by growing gross domestic product (GDP), increasing market liberalisation and free trade, as well as according more power to the World Trade Organization."

12.2 Four Structural Critiques (slide 31)

Keywords: technocentric, ethnocentric, commodification of nature, sustaining development vs developing sustainability, Daly

- **Technocentric** — faith that technology will fix environmental limits.
- **Ethnocentric** — a Western framing of needs and nature imposed globally.
- **Capitalisation and commodification of nature** — nature re-described as capital to be priced and traded.
- Sustaining development rather than developing sustainability — the adjective colonises the noun: the objective becomes keeping the development machine running, not becoming sustainable.

- Herman Daly (former World Bank economist): 'The term sustainable growth should be rejected as a bad oxymoron'.

→ Structural point: sustainability is **subordinate to development**, exactly as the social agenda was subordinate to the market in Section 9.

13. Paradigms Compared: Where the Alternatives Sit (slides 17 & 32)

Keywords: course map, who needs development, how, importance, comparison across paradigms

The paradigm grid (slides 17 and 32) locates each paradigm by three questions — **Who needs development? How should it happen? What is the importance?** Condensed:

- Modernisation — traditional un-industrialised (non-Western) societies; mutually supportive modernisation plus foreign assistance; route to civilisation and freedom from material want.
- Dependency — peripheral countries (e.g. Latin America); equal trade, technology transfer, changed class relations; reduce surplus extraction, pursue self-reliance.
- Neo-liberalism — indebted and post-socialist states reeling from structural adjustment; privatisation, free markets, deregulation, good governance, social capital; spur growth, make globalisation work for the poor.
- Developmental State — East Asian countries; corporatism, entrepreneurial bureaucracy, export promotion; expand into the global economy, preserve national pride.
- Human Development — **vulnerable and marginalised individuals**; meet human needs through better, holistic measures; reach the poorest, prevent 'everyday' violence, secure **freedom to pursue own choices**.
- Sustainable Development — **current and future generations**; balance growth against environmental degradation, long-term planning, consideration of both mankind and the environment.
- **Post-development** — the final row, blank on slide 17: the next paradigm the course turns to.

→ The alternatives change *who* the subject is (individuals, future generations) and *how* it is judged (freedoms, long-term balance) — but neither repudiates the development project itself.

14. Conclusion: What the Alternatives Change — and Leave Alone (slides 33–34)

Keywords: shift from national priorities, new foundations, private sector untouched, humanise neoliberalism

- Human development theory shifted planners' focus **away from national-level priorities**, introducing new theoretical foundations and new areas of focus.
- It required **states and aid agencies** to adopt different approaches to development.
- But it **left the private sector largely unaffected** — and the same problem recurs for sustainable development.
- Sustainable development as a policy framework is a platform for international discussion of how development should be achieved.
- Yet it has **not fully answered what sustainability truly means** — i.e. what is to be sustained (back to slide 21).
- Closing question: **is sustainable development essentially a way to humanise neoliberalism?**

→ Both alternatives are **reforms of the mainstream**: they change what is measured and who is counted, while leaving the growth-and-market architecture intact.

15. Seminar Question and Week 5 Preview (slides 29 & 36)

Keywords: SDG coherence test, agents of development, World Bank, governmentality, professionalisation

- Discussion task (slide 29): test the SDGs against Sen's *Development as Freedom* and for internal **coherence** — do Goal 8's growth logic and Goals 13, 12 and 10 pull in opposite directions?
- Housekeeping (slide 35): **Quiz 1** — closed-book, in person (venue LI 4208, 9am sharp), marked on quality of argument, structure of argument, and evidence of subject knowledge.
- **Week 5 — Agents of Development** (slide 36): essential readings Li (2007) (*The Will to Improve* — governmentality and the practice of politics) and Sondarjee (2021) (change and stability at the World Bank); supplementary Kothari (2005) on the professionalisation of development.

→ Week 5 asks **who actually does development** — the actors, experts and institutions that carry the theories forward.

16. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: exam recap, definitions, critiques, paradigm map, one-liners

1. **Framing (slide 3):** is development more than GDP? Mainstream = growth and national aggregates; alternatives = well-being, freedoms, future generations.
2. **Basic Needs (ILO 1976, World Bank):** minimum standard of living a society sets for its poorest; necessities + public goods + participation; 'agency achievements'; flawed growth models → redistribution.
3. **Entitlements (Sen, Nussbaum):** famines come from failed command over food, not scarcity; entitlements = commodity bundles commanded through rights and opportunities.

4. **Capabilities (slide 8):** poverty = capability deprivation; 'beings and doings'; substantive freedoms to achieve the life one values, not commodity acquisition.
5. **Development as Freedom (slide 9):** expanding real freedoms; freedom is **both means and ends**; five freedoms — political, economic facilities, social opportunities, transparency guarantees, protective security.
6. **Evolution (slide 10):** Nussbaum's gender justice → gender-specific measures; Human Development Approach → UNDP Human Development Report and Index.
7. **HDI (slide 11):** life expectancy at birth; expected + mean years of schooling; GNI per capita (PPP).
8. **MDGs (slides 12–13):** "UNDP meets World Bank", 2000–2015. **Met:** extreme poverty, gender parity, malaria, water. **Missed:** work, hunger, education, mortality, reproductive health, HIV/AIDS, TB, sanitation, environment.
9. **Critiques of human development (slides 14–16):** fetishism of numbers (ASER 2018: ~50% of Class 5 could not read Class 2 text); unrepresentative data (Hickel 2023); adjunct to neoliberalism (Pieterse: "business-as-usual with a human face").
10. **Sustainable Development (slides 19–20):** no single definition; Brundtland 1987 — present needs without compromising future generations; needs + equity, and needs vary by culture.
11. **Framework and history (slides 21–24):** corrects but does not replace the existing model; Rio+20 (2012) third SD conference; *The Future We Want* leads with growth; unanswered — what is to be sustained: resources, resource income, production, or consumption?
12. **SDGs (slides 25–26):** 17 goals, balanced across three dimensions; aspirational, universal with national flexibility, government-led; test coherence against Sen (slide 29).
13. **Critiques of sustainable development (slides 30–31):** weak sustainability, growth vs sustainability, inequality ignored (Salleh); technocentric, ethnocentric, commodification of nature, sustaining development rather than developing sustainability; Daly — 'sustainable growth' is a bad oxymoron.
14. **Paradigms (slides 17 & 32):** human development = vulnerable individuals, holistic measures, freedom of choice; sustainable development = current and future generations, balance growth with environment.
15. **Conclusion (slides 33–34):** human development shifted planners from national priorities but left the **private sector untouched**; sustainability's core question unanswered; a **humanisation of neoliberalism**?
16. **Next (slide 36):** Week 5 — Agents of Development (Li 2007, Sondarjee 2021); Quiz 1 covers the course so far.